

150kg. When people who know nothing about para athletes see me lifting, they can't believe it. On the street, they might see only a "disabled" person, but in the gym or on the field, I show them something they never imagined. That moment, when their perception changes, is what I enjoy most.

Jumping is my passion. At 165cm tall, I cleared 2.08m in Paris. That's a 43cm difference. The world record, whether for able-bodied or para athletes, is a 57cm gap. That's my dream target. If I can reach 2.09m or 2.10m in Delhi, I'll start believing I can chase that number.

People sometimes ask why I set my sights so high. I already have a Paralympic gold, after all. But I've never thought of myself as just a para athlete. I want to inspire everyone.

That mindset goes back to my childhood in Jewar. My teachers didn't want me to compete in high jump because they thought I'd hurt myself. I had one leg with a disability,

Golden leap: At just 22, Praveen Kumar has become a double Paralympic medallist, upgrading his Tokyo silver with a gold medal in the men's T64 high jump at Paris 2024.

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but my other leg was springy. So I insisted. That stubbornness paid off. I became the best jumper in my school — and then the best in India. I even won gold at the CBSE school Nationals against able-bodied athletes. Some competitors resented losing to someone with a disability. At first, they didn't mind me joining in because they never believed I could beat them. Once I did, they wanted me moved to "my own" category.

That's how I learned about para sports. I found my coach, Satyapal Singh sir, at Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium. In my very first trial there, I cleared 1.80m. He called the other athletes and told them I was the kind of example he wanted. I've been training with him ever since.

Talent alone isn't enough — you need someone to believe in you. Satyapal sir has been that for me,

especially during my lowest moment in 2019. At the Junior World Championships, I was classified into a tougher category than expected. I had prepared for a field where the record was 1.95m, but suddenly I was up against a record of 2.19m. I felt defeated and quit the sport for a few months. He kept persuading me to return, and eventually I did. That decision led me to Tokyo, where I won silver, and then to Paris, where I fulfilled my dream.

I've come far, but I know there's more to do. I've never won a World Championship medal. I want to stand on the podium in Delhi, not just for myself but for everyone who sees me jump. Many people in the stands may not even know my name. That's fine. I want them to leave thinking, "I didn't know he could do that."

As told to Jonathan Selvaraj

